

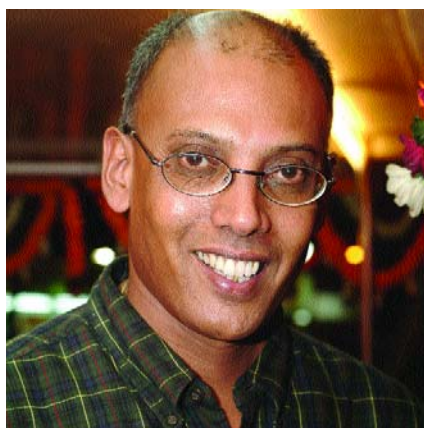
However, without an online business networking tool such as LinkedIn, it's hard to know who to ask for an introduction, and it places a burden on the connector, which in turn makes it less likely that you get an introduction."

Companies have realised the effectiveness of such Web sites for job listings over conventional job Web sites. The advantages are obvious—both the recruiter and the applicant are spared the harrowing task of going through innumerable pages of listings, and the person is also known to someone or the other in the network. A certain headhunter claims to have generated business worth lakhs just through Ryze. But this does not sound the death knell for job Web sites—in fact, these have begun to form groups within their Web sites for effective searching.

Value to self

Ramgopal Rao, Managing Director, Argosy InterSearch India Ltd, a global recruitment firm, declares on his Ryze page, "I have access to three important people with just three phone calls—the US President, the Russian President and the Pope! I am confident of reducing the phone call to just one." Before you begin to be awed about the person's address book, you too can be like him. Surprised? That's an additional advantage of social networking—the six degrees of separation can be reduced dramatically.

All networking Web sites let you regis-



KRISHNA UNNI, Founder, Pigtail Pundits

“An online introduction is just the beginning—it's not like you register today, and expect Crores of business tomorrow”

ter your personal interests and hobbies. Ramrao, a businessman, met Abhijit Bam, another budding entrepreneur, and discovered a mutual passion for cars. The Ryze Mumbai Business Mixer has an eclectic mix of a florist, a social activist, IT professionals, marketing consultants, as well as people with small businesses. And they are not the sole such mix. Sridhar Krishnan, Founder

and Chief Technology Officer at Encover.com, California, also has friends from India on his network.

The Bangalore Business Network also boasts of professionals working in India, as well as from abroad. Says Deepa Thomas, a PR professional at Marico, "As a communications person, I view these Web sites as a quicker way to reach many diverse people at the same time—something that even a concrete association might not offer."

Verma finds it easier to approach people online, and is confident of the support of his fellow networkers for his new venture.

The business rationale

Business Developer 2.0, a Fortune Group magazine, hailed social networking as the 'Technology of 2003'. That says it all. Friendster reportedly received \$14 million as venture capital, whilst Spoke was in for \$9 million. Google, the world's favourite search engine, has also jumped on to the bandwagon by launching its social service engine—Orkut.com.

LinkedIn has almost four million registered users, while the San Francisco based Tribe has 1,40,000 registered users according to its Public Relations Manager, Valerie Garing. Ryze has over 200 networks constantly interacting with each other. Amazingly, the founders of Yahoo!, eBay and Netscape are all users of LinkedIn.

It's happening...on your cell phone

Mobile phones may be the answer to enhance social networking. According to Ashwyn Kumar Attarwar, Executive Director, Gametrix Entertainment Pvt Ltd, Hyderabad, mobile phones offer anytime interactivity, and hence, they will become an important tool to manage contacts.

With technological advances in both mobile handsets and network capabilities, data services are expected to grow exponentially.

Gametrix is already engaged in developing games, animations and related media content for wireless and Internet-capable devices. So the next time you network with a friend in Delhi, you can invite him to play chess on your cell phone!



Introduced online, meet offline—the Mumbai Business Network Mixer meeting